

For the other Birthright, Matt decides to fall back on his idea about the domovoi being nearly silent. He decides to give the kith an Acuity Birthright—domovoi receive a -1 difficulty to all Stealth rolls, and cannot botch Stealth rolls. He asks the Storyteller if domovoi can also gain some kind of bonus when in their family's home. The Storyteller suggests that if the domovoi is in the house, sleeping family members don't wake up until sunrise unless the domovoi wishes them to. Matt likes that idea—it means that, if necessary, his domovoi character can bring the motley to the family's house in the middle of the night to reconnoiter. He calls this Birthright **Silent Protector**.

Step Four: Frailty

For the domovoi Frailty, Matt wants to fall back on their propensity to throw things around if they are treated badly, but he doesn't want to give them some kind of "fit of rage" Frailty, since he finds that a bit cliché. Instead, he thinks about the bond between family and domovoi, and what would happen if it was broken. He decides that this Frailty is called **Bonds of Family**. If a domovoi breaks his oath to the family—allowing it to come to harm, refusing to help the family members, and so on, the domovoi cannot regain Glamour until he makes restitution. If the family breaks the oath (rejecting the domovoi, for example), the domovoi simply loses access to his Adopted Family Birthright until he can find a new family or patch things up with the original one.

Step Five: Affinity

As domovoi are so closely tied to humanity, Actor is the obvious choice for their affinity Realm.

Step Six: Adjust as Necessary

Matt looks over everything he's decided about the domovoi, and checks with his Storyteller. He thinks that the kith looks pretty well constructed—it's true to the mythology about the domovoi, but very appropriate for **Changeling: The Dreaming**. With the Storyteller's approval, Matt moves on to the character creation phase (which you can read about in Chapter Three).

Noble Houses

The Shining Host long ago divided itself into great houses, who in turn represent different elements and interests of the Seelie and Unseelie Courts. Though the sidhe returned to a world that had all but abandoned such feudal concepts, the fact remains that the dreams of monarchy and idealized nobility remain, and none can deny that the Dreaming itself backed their claims. Like it or not, the houses rule the political landscape of the Kithain, and so understanding them is critical for any changeling who hopes to make an impact on fae society.

Each noble house is a culture unto itself, with rites and traditions going back centuries. Those who seek to buck the established order thus face stiff opposition, though mavericks feel the reward of changing house practices can be worth the risk. Internal house politics are the epitome of ruthless courtesy,

as it is seen as poor form to openly go against one's "relatives," and yet there is often little alternative for those who wish to climb the ladder. Given that Arcadian sidhe currently control a large part of the nobility, it is perhaps unsurprising that bias against titled commoners and even Autumn sidhe runs deep in all but the most unorthodox houses.

Of course, internal struggles are set against the backdrop of politics between houses, and since open warfare is frowned upon among the nobility, that only makes the intrigues and backstabbing even more ruthless. Nor is all politicking across the court divide, though that certainly is a big arena; conflicts between houses of the same court are common as different values and philosophies collide. Add personal elements like unlikely friendships or old grudges into the mix, and it all makes for an ever-shifting array of alliances, betrayals, favors, gossip, duels, parties, and conspiracies that can raise a savvy noble to the heights of power—or tear her down just as fast.

What follows is a brief overview of each of the great houses of Kithain society, providing a look at their history, their role in the political landscape, how they came to return to the Autumn world, and some of the common habits and traits of their members. The house's Boon and Flaw, special traits acquired by all nobles of the house, are also detailed, and should be carefully noted by players of noble characters. Lastly, a gallery of famous members showcases noteworthy political players and rising stars, as well as provides the Storyteller with potential supporting characters to use when dealing with that house.

It is also worth noting that while rank terms have been standardized for simplicity's sake, nobles often receive alternatives or additions to the standard titles, ones that better reflect a noble's specific duties as well as a house's unique culture and perspective. A Gwydion investigator might receive the formal title of Lord Inquisitor, rather than simply "Baron," for example, while a ruthless Balor leader may hold the rank of "Lieutenant General" instead of "Countess." At formal events or in settings where this might cause confusion, the standard title is used first, followed by the house-specific one: "May I present Lord Bayard Tyrael, Storm-Champion of House Eiluned."

House Aesin

(EE-sin)

My eternal soul now lies with House Aesin. I swear by the forests and mountains of my home that I will uphold the traditions and customs of House Aesin. Knowing I reach safety, I seek shelter beneath the wings of the owl. If my oath is broken, may the Dreaming strip me of all privileges and never let me forget who I was and what I have become.

Court: Unseelie

Nickname: Northmen, Beasts (vulgar)

The Guardians of the North, hailing from Scandinavia, once gifted the Vikings with their knowledge in order to stave off the tide of Christianity and the Banality they feared it would bring. They prefer the forests and mountains of their native lands to cities, finding respite and normalcy in nature. They look upon the mortal bodies they were forced to claim as